

VERBATIM

A Word-for-Word Musical

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PLOT SUMMARY

VERBATIM is a two-hander musical about how a person can either parrot falsehoods or make the best of their livelihood when the world shuns them. After their expulsion for cheating on their journalism final, Timi befriends a parrot who escaped the zoo that Timi wrote their latest article about.

In the dean's office, Timi faces consequences for cheating. The university expels them ("Copy That, Verbatim"). Meanwhile, a parrot runs into Timi's glass door at home. Timi looks in the mirror, calling themselves a failure ("The Fiasco You Know"). The parrot harmonizes. Timi realizes the zoo escapee is at their doorstep. Some time ago, Timi interviewed this silent bird to no avail. Timi patches up the parrot and names them "Lo" for their voice and it also counters Timi's surname "La" ("La Lo").

Timi falls asleep with autoplay on. Lo picks up on the self-help content. Lo gives Timi a good meal ("Help Yourself"). Mira calls and wonders where Timi has been. Timi admits they were expelled ("Spell It Out"). Mira invites Timi out to a show that they are disc jockeying. Timi has a good time until they get into a fight ("Lip Sync"). They end up in the slammer. Unable to feed Lo and also unable to reveal this zoo escapee to authorities, Lo starves ("A Mouthful"). Timi returns home to find that Lo is alive but does not realize Lo is dead inside ("Dead Silence").

Lo remembers the last thing the police say before dropping Timi off was "to get a job." The autoplay eventually lands on commentary channels. Lo no longer calls themselves "Lo" but Liu. Timi wakes up to Dingoes Report with Liu constantly telling Timi to get a job. Liu also peddles inflammatory news meant to rile up viewers, but Timi sees through it as a former journalism student. However, having lost their scholarship, Timi loses any financial support from their family. They have bills to pay ("Money Talks"). Timi investigates the job requirements, but they require a college degree. In a nasally voice, Liu repeats that Timi must argue that they dropped out of college due to the college bubble ("They Think They Know What's Best"). Timi lands the job as their science investigative intern. Mira calls, but Timi does not share this good news. Mira lets Timi know of their research summer internship and invites them to a luncheon.

Mira and Timi visit the lab, where Timi secretly documents. Timi cannot get in fights here. Timi picks up on false cues about DNA duplication with Mira's research on mimicry ("Mimicry"). Timi publishes them. Timi gets promoted to investigative reporter while Mira loses their internship ("Half-Truths"). Timi cannot see themselves in Mira and they go their separate ways ("Get Ahead

in Life or Ahead of Yourself"). Timi grows successful yet lonely without Mira ("Alienate the Canary").

After some time, Mira reaches out as an emerging bandleader of The Canaries. Mira shares with Timi their first EP on a flash drive. Timi puts the drive in their computer and plays a song. Suddenly, The Canaries's social media publishes pictures of Timi and special guest Liu currently at home. Animal control is outside. Timi releases Lo/Liu ("Word For Word").

VERBATIM is a word-for-word consideration of where an aspiring follower would go after a misstep or what they will say after misspeaking.

CAST OF CHARACTERS

TIMI LÃ, adult, a person who finds meaning by reacting, they were a science journalism student before being caught cheating

LO/LIU, a parrot, Timi's pet who parrots goodness or badness ///

MIRA GAITÁN, adult, Timi's lifelong friend, they are a geneticist and disc jockey

✿ Androgyny Ornithology: Each character resembles the androgynous nature, with open-ended vocal requirements

✿ People of the Global Majority most represent the experiences of these people and birds; cast accordingly

MUSICAL NUMBERS

1. "Copy That" Timi
2. "The Fiasco You Know" Timi, Lo
3. "La Lo" Timi, Lo
4. "Help Yourself" Lo, Timi
5. "Spell It Out" Timi, Mira
6. "Lip Sync" Mira, Timi
7. "A Mouthful" Timi
8. "Dead Silence" Timi, Lo
9. "Money Talks" Liu, Timi
10. "They Think They Know What's Best" Liu, Timi
11. "Mimicry" Mira, Timi
12. "Half-Truths" Timi, Liu
13. "Get Ahead in Life or Ahead of Yourself" Mira, Timi
14. "Alienate the Canary" Timi
15. "Word For Word" Mira, Timi, Lo/Liu